

Typography Tokens and Web Font Report

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Site Details

My live typography page is at <https://pwoolls1.github.io/WDD331R/index.html> and the source code is at <https://github.com/pwoolls1/WDD331R>.

Reflection

Fluid versus Fixed

I chose to make my larger heading and display sizes fluid while keeping body text, captions, and smaller supporting text fixed. Headings benefit from scaling because they help establish hierarchy and can feel either too dominant on small screens or too understated on large screens if they remain the same size everywhere. Fluid sizing allows them to adapt naturally to the available space.

I kept body text fixed because readability is the primary concern. If body text scaled continuously, it could become too small on narrow screens or unnecessarily large on wider displays, disrupting the reading experience. Captions and smaller interface text also work best at predictable sizes. If every step had been fluid, the entire interface could have felt inconsistent and harder to read. If none of the steps had been fluid, the site would have lost some of the responsiveness and visual polish that fluid typography provides.

Choosing font-display

I used font-display: swap for Merriweather because it provides the best balance between performance and aesthetics for a heading font. With this approach, visitors immediately see text rendered in the fallback font while the custom font loads in the background. Once Merriweather becomes available, the headings update automatically.

If I had used block, visitors on slower connections might have experienced invisible text until the font loaded, which would negatively affect usability. Using optional could have resulted in some visitors never seeing the custom font at all if the connection was poor. Since Merriweather plays an important branding role without being essential for readability, swap offered the most appropriate tradeoff.

The Two-Layer Token System

The two-layer token system proved valuable because it separated design decisions from implementation details. Instead of assigning scale steps directly throughout the site, I mapped those steps to semantic roles such as body text, captions, and headings. This made it much easier to update the typography system because changes only needed to occur in one location.

I noticed the same benefits when working with the color system earlier in the course. Using semantic tokens improved consistency and reduced the chance of introducing one-off values. If I rebuilt the typography system from scratch, I would spend more time planning the scale before implementation. I initially focused on getting the sizes working, but a more deliberate approach to defining the hierarchy first would have made the rollout across the site even smoother. Overall, the token system made the site easier to maintain and reinforced the value of treating typography as a design system rather than a collection of individual font-size declarations.